

The Responsa Resume Guide

A lean, two-page structure built around how contracting officers and program managers actually evaluate talent — and how we match you to the right requirement. This is guidance, not a rigid template: adapt it to your own background.

Why this structure

A CO or PM reviewing candidates is skimming, not reading — a resume that buries your strongest qualification on page 4 loses to one that leads with it. The single strongest predictor of fit for an engagement is **direct experience under the same contract type**: FFP work demonstrates estimating and scoping discipline; T&M work demonstrates sustained trust and responsiveness; FFP-LOE sits between the two. Tag it explicitly, every time — it is the first thing we and the requiring office both look for.

What COs and PMs actually look for

- Proof of delivery under the **same contract type** the requirement uses — not just a similar job title.
- A clearance already in hand, stated plainly up front — it removes an onboarding risk before they even call you.
- Specialized, plain-language expertise over a generic labor-category title.
- Concrete, measurable outcomes (schedule, cost, quality) over a list of duties performed.
- A document short enough to attach to a source-selection file without trimming it themselves.

Page 1 — Header, summary, and your strongest work

1. Header (2–3 lines)

Name, city/state, and — only if applicable — clearance level and citizenship. Leave off anything not applicable rather than writing "None"; an empty line reads faster than a negative one. Contact details are optional here since Responsa already has them on file, but include an email if this resume may be forwarded directly to a requiring office.

2. Summary (3–4 lines)

Years of relevant experience, your specialization in plain language (not a labor category), and the one or two qualifications that most distinguish you for federal work — a clearance, a specific contract-type track record, a domain few others cover.

3. Relevant experience (the core of the resume)

List your most recent and most relevant engagements first. For each one:

Role / Client (agency name, or "Federal client" if non-disclosable)

Mon YYYY – Mon YYYY

CONTRACT TYPE: FFP / FFP-LOE / T&M

- What you did, for whom, using what approach or tool — one line.
- The measurable result: schedule held, cost avoided, quality metric hit, deliverable accepted.
- Two to four bullets per engagement is plenty — this is a highlight reel, not a duty log.

Every bullet should answer: *what did you do, for whom, how, and with what result?* Skip anything that doesn't.

Page 2 — Earlier experience, credentials, and skills

4. Earlier experience (compressed)

Older or less directly relevant roles get one or two lines each, not the full treatment above. The goal is coverage, not depth — page 1 already made your case.

5. Education

Degree, institution, year. Relevant coursework or honors only if directly applicable.

6. Certifications & clearances

Active clearances first (level and, if known, investigation type), then relevant professional certifications (PMP, Security+, CISSP, domain-specific licenses, etc.).

7. Core skills

A short keyword list — tools, methodologies, domains. This is scanned as much as read, by us and by the requiring office, so keep it concrete and specific rather than generic ("Agile/Scrum, Primavera P6, cost estimating, DoD acquisition lifecycle" beats "project management").

Formatting checklist

- Two pages, maximum — one is fine if that's genuinely all you need.
- 0.5–0.75" margins, a clean sans-serif font, 10–11pt body text.
- Export to PDF before sharing the link — formatting holds, edits don't happen by accident.
- No photo, no classified or CUI content, no information you wouldn't want forwarded to a stranger.

Once it's ready, link it from the "Resume link" field on your Responsa vetting form (vet.html) — a Google Doc link with view access for anyone with the link works well.

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